

1.4.3.10 Tackling

Tackling is a technical skill that enables the defender to win the ball from an opposing player or knock it away from them. Along with the two other ways of winning the ball (anticipating early and intercepting a pass), it enables the defender to break up the opponents' move.

It is a core technical concept requiring considerable tenacity and physical strength.

Tackling is not always the best option; sometimes it is better to avoid doing so (in some situations it is better to wait).

When coaches want to teach players how to tackle, they can use a theoretical approach. However, to ensure the players acquire the skill properly it is essential to set up one-on-one situations (even though this increases the risk of injuries).

There are three types of tackle: block tackle; side-on tackle; sliding tackle.

Block tackle

In a block tackle, the defender and the attacker are facing one another.

It is important to be in a side-on rather than a front-on position (with one leg slightly in front of the other).

Body weight must be evenly balanced, with legs slightly bent and ready to move.

Centre of gravity should be as low as possible to increase stability and strength.

The ball should be attacked quickly and with leg muscles taut so that the leg does not yield.

First method (traditional approach): with stronger (tackling) foot starting further back, attack the ball with the inside of the foot or instep.

Second method: leading with their stronger foot, the defender takes their opponent by surprise by going for the ball straightaway, using the leading foot, i.e. the one closest to the ball.

Side-on and sliding tackles

A defender tackles side-on when an opponent is running with the ball and the defender runs

alongside them in the same direction; the defender can execute the tackle when they reach the line of the ball. The defender uses the inside of the instep of the foot furthest away from the attacker, pivoting on the other foot and turning their body towards the opponent.

The sliding tackle is used when the defender is unable to tackle side-on, intervening with the near foot (outside of the instep) or far foot (inside of the instep). Doing this can present a tactical risk, as once the defender is on the ground – if they have failed to win the ball – they are unable to defend.

1.4.3.11 Anticipating and intercepting a pass

An **interception** is made when a defender breaks up an attacking move by going straight for the ball.

In **anticipating** play, a defender cuts out a pass intended for the player they are marking.

- In order to reach the ball before an opponent, the defender should be well positioned on the passing angle and should avoid making contact with their opponent (keeping them roughly an arm's length away).
- The defender needs to read the path of the ball and be on their toes (sense of anticipation).

The defender needs to be very careful, because if they miss the ball they will put the whole defence in danger.

1.4.3.12 Defending the goal

A player defends their team's goal by putting their body between the forward on the ball and the goal, positioning themselves along a straight line between the attacker and the goal. The defender must not turn away (e.g. because they are afraid of being hit) if their opponent shapes to shoot, as this makes it easier for the attacker to dribble past them, in which case the goal would be left exposed. After the opponent has taken their shot, the defender must run back quickly to provide cover in case the keeper fails to hold onto the ball. If the defender slides in to try to defend the goal they must be sure they can win the ball; otherwise it is better that they stay on their feet as long as possible.

1.5 GROUP TACTICS

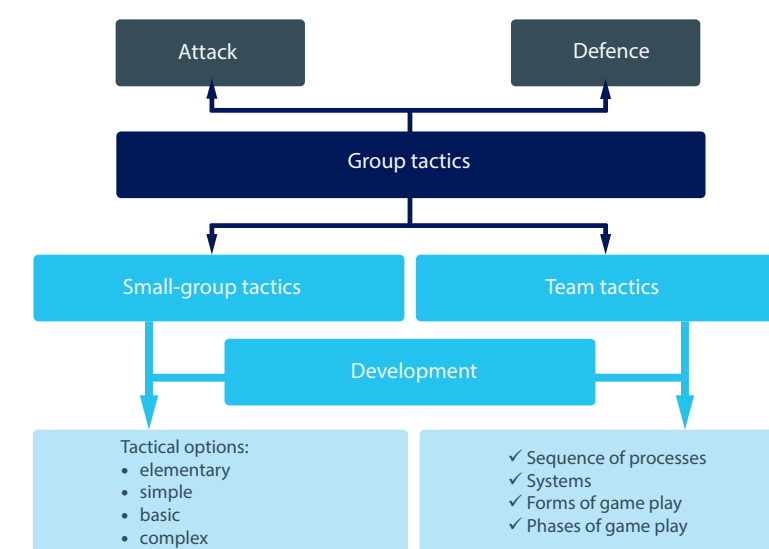
1.5.1 Introduction to group tactics

The group-based dimension of play is what makes team sports so rich in a tactical sense. As players begin to play in combination, they move beyond the world of individual tactics (without abandoning them) and enter into the world of **group tactics**. We will discuss the varying actions that must be managed and coordinated within group play, by teams as a whole and small groups of players within a team:

1. Small-group technical/tactical options
2. Tactical processes (complex tactical options)
3. Phases of play
4. Forms of game play
5. Systems

These actions may include a group of two or three players (**small-group tactics**), or the whole team (**team tactics**).

An outline of group tactics



Based on the *Conceptual Map of the Preparation of Group Tactics* (Antón, J. L., 1998)